

LIVE



NEWSPAPER

10th July, 2017

ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

28th WEEK



TRI - JUNCTION

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... INDIA AND ITS NEIGHBORHOOD- RELATIONS.

3 Power games at the tri-junction

The current border stand-off suggests India is likely to become bolder in resisting the idea of power disparity



SHASHANK JOSHI

We should by now be accustomed to Sino-Indian summits occurring with the backdrop of border trouble, and Friday's G20 meeting between a smiling Prime Minister Narendra Modi and a less enthused Chinese President Xi Jinping was no exception. But the Doka La stand-off, at the southern tip of the Chumbi Valley where India, Bhutan, and China meet, is perhaps the most significant of all the border confrontations that have roiled the India-China relationship in recent years. This is not because of its size, dwarfed by the Sumdorong Chu crisis of 1986-87, or duration, still only a few days longer than the Daulat Beg Oldi stand-off of 2013. Rather, the importance of the incident is threefold.

What it implies

One factor is the unique position of the Chumbi Valley, which is at once a dangerous conduit into the slender Siliguri Corridor and a dangerous choke point, exposed on both sides, for Chinese forces. A second factor is that this tussle is formally over the interests and rights of a third country, Bhutan, echoing the wider competition for influence in smaller countries – Nepal, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Sri Lanka, the Maldives, and elsewhere – across the Indo-Pacific region. Third, the stand-off comes in a period when it is clear that the wheels are coming off the India-China wagon, with Indian trust in Chinese intentions collapsing



SHUTTERSTOCK/SHUTTERSTOCK

steadily and Beijing taking an ever-more strident tone.

At the military level, India has good reason to prevent Chinese road building near Doka La. Chinese activity has steadily increased in the area beneath Bhutan's claim-line, pushing the area under its de facto control about 5 km southwards, towards a crucial ridge-line. This has a number of implications. It would widen the area of Chinese control in an otherwise very narrow valley, from around 8-9 km (Batang La to the Amo Chu river) to 12-13 km (Gamochen to the river), thereby easing the logistics of moving large numbers of troops. Control of the dominating ridgeline would also give China a strong position, by some accounts even domination, over Indian posts to the west, and Bhutanese ones to the south and east.

India is still well short of matching the impressive infrastructure development in Tibet over the past decade, with two-thirds of sanctioned roads on the Line of Actual Control (LAC) still un-built. But Chinese forces moving through the Chumbi Valley – 90 km from top to bottom – would have long, exposed flanks. India has a formidable set of forces arrayed to the

west, with mountain divisions in Gangtok (17th), Kalimpong (27th), and Binaguri (20th) further to the south, all of which are part of the Siliguri-based 33 Corps. Furthermore, the 59th division of 17 Corps, India's first mountain strike corps, raised for the purpose of offensive operations into Tibet, is headquartered in Panagarh and will reportedly be operational this year. It's worth noting that former National Security Advisor (NSA) Shivshankar Menon has argued, in his 2016 book *Choke*, that Beijing backed down in the 2013 Depsang incident "to a great extent because of India's improved capabilities, which left the Chinese in no doubt that India could embarrass them".

The Bhutan advantage

Another of India's military advantages is its privileged relationship with Bhutan. This allows it to bring to bear large forces from the east. A sizeable Indian Military Training Team (IMTRAT) is permanently based in western Bhutan, while other units regularly cooperate with the Royal Bhutan Army. Bhutan's involvement highlights the way in which Sino-Indian competition is increasingly channelled through third countries, as China relentlessly expands into India's

periphery through strategic investments, trading relationships and arms sales. India's willingness to intervene forcefully in a bilateral Bhutan-China dispute is a reflection both of India's own vital interests in the Chumbi Valley and of its commanding position in Bhutan, which might otherwise have ceded the Doklam plateau to China in a territorial swap many years ago. The India-Bhutan Friendship Treaty, though revised in 2007 to give Thimpu more autonomy, still notes that the two countries "shall cooperate closely with each other on issues relating to their national interests". In this sense, Bhutan is a special case. But in stepping across an international border and defying Chinese expectations, India has also signalled a degree of confidence that will resonate more widely. This in part explains the especially vituperative rhetoric that has seeped out of hyper-nationalist outlets like the *Global Times* in recent days, such as lurid promises to "liberate" Sikkim and Bhutan, as well as subtler steps such as this week's travel advisory for Chinese citizens in India.

There is a reasonable chance that this stand-off will end within weeks, with China quietly halting road construction and Indian troops returning westward to their posts. The risk of escalation appears low. More broadly, the thicket of border agreements accumulated over the past 30 years – in 1988, 1993, 1996, 2002, and 2013 – serve as an important cushion whose value is still not fully appreciated.

But the wider context is one of relentlessly hardening attitudes, on both sides. Beijing is aggrieved by the Dalai Lama's visit to Tawang in April, India's aggressive repudi-

ation of the Belt and Road Initiative in May, and India's forward-leaning posture in the South China Sea – the latter underscored by Vietnam's two-year extension of a 2006 oil concession to ONGC Videsh last week. India's complaints are too numerous and familiar to elaborate, but they span international institutions (membership of the Nuclear Suppliers Group), terrorism (Masood Azhar), sovereignty (China-Pakistan Economic Corridor) and, in a more inchoate way, questions of the basic security order in Asia.

Relationship in a flux

"India-China relations are undergoing a change," wrote former Foreign Secretary Shyam Saran on July 3. "China believes that India should acknowledge the power disparity between the two sides and show appropriate deference to China." India has always repudiated this idea. But it is likely to become bolder in doing so. This is evident in last month's U.S.-India joint statement, where China was unmentioned but all pervasive in areas from North Korea, to trade, to freedom of navigation. It is on display in the Bay of Bengal, where one of the largest-ever iterations of the Malabar exercise series is getting underway with aircraft carriers/helicopter carrier from India, the U.S., and Japan. We see it also in this weekend's news, reported in this newspaper, that the government is conducting a national security review of Chinese investment in South Asia. Perhaps, in the coming weeks, 17 Corps will suddenly find that the purse strings have become looser too.

Shashank Joshi is a Senior Research Fellow of the Royal United Services Institute in London



ISSUE NO: 1

WESTERN SECTOR



- In 1865, W. H. Johnson, a civil servant with the Survey of India proposed the "Johnson Line", which put Aksai Chin in Kashmir.
- China has got reservations over this line.
- India sticks to the Johnson Line.
- This separates Jammu & Kashmir with Xinjiang Province of China.
- India accuses China of illegally occupying Aksai Chin as well as parts of Ladakh region.
- 1962 war saw fierce fighting between the two sides.
- Tense stand-offs occasionally take place.



ISSUE NO: 2

MIDDLE SECTOR



- Here the border is least controversial.
- Himachal Pradesh and Uttarakhand abet the boundary.
- Both sides do not have much disagreement over this area.



ISSUE NO: 3

EASTERN SECTOR

SIKKIM REGION



- On March 17, 1890, top officials from British India and China signed a treaty to demarcate the boundary between Tibet and Sikkim.
- The boundary of Sikkim and Tibet shall be the crest of the mountain range separating the waters flowing into the Sikkim Teesta and its affluents from the waters flowing into the Tibetan Mochu and northwards into other rivers of Tibet.



ISSUE NO: 4

EASTERN SECTOR

ARUNACHAL REGION



- In 1913, Tibet declared independence
- But, the subsequent Chinese government did not recognize this.
- 1914 Shimla Accord defined McMahon line as the new boundary between Tibet and British India (China initiated but not signed)
- Chinese map shows some 65,000 sq km of the territory south of the line as part of the Tibet Autonomous Region, which they call it as South Tibet.

- China says Tibet was not sovereign and did not have the power to conclude treaties.
- This is the reason, why China issues stapled visas to people from Arunachal Pradesh.

CHINA

Learning Space





CHINA

SIKKIM

BHUTAN

NEPAL

INDIA

BANGLADESH

MYANMAR

(BURMA)





DOKLAM CONTROVERSY

BHUTAN'S VIEW



- Doklam is also known as Donglong area of the Sikkim sector.
- China was constructing motorable road from Dokola towards Bhutan army camp.
- It affects the boundary between the two countries.
- Bhutan asked Beijing to restore status quo by stopping the work.
- Donglong is a tri-junction area near the Chumbi Valley.
- It is under China's control, however, Bhutan claims sovereignty over the area.
- Both have written agreements during 1988 and 1998, stating that the two sides agree to maintain tranquillity in their border areas pending a final settlement on the boundary question.
- It was also decided to maintain status quo on the boundary as before March, 1959.



DOKLAM CONTROVERSY

CHINA'S VIEW



- China says that its personnel are operating in Chinese territory.
- China also says Indian troops have transgressed into Chinese territory.
- It says Sikkim sector of the border has a clear legal basis.
- According to the Convention between China and Great Britain in 1890, the boundary of Sikkim and Tibet shall be the crest of the mountain range separating border with water flows towards the Teesta.



BROADER CONTEXT



CHINA's POINTS

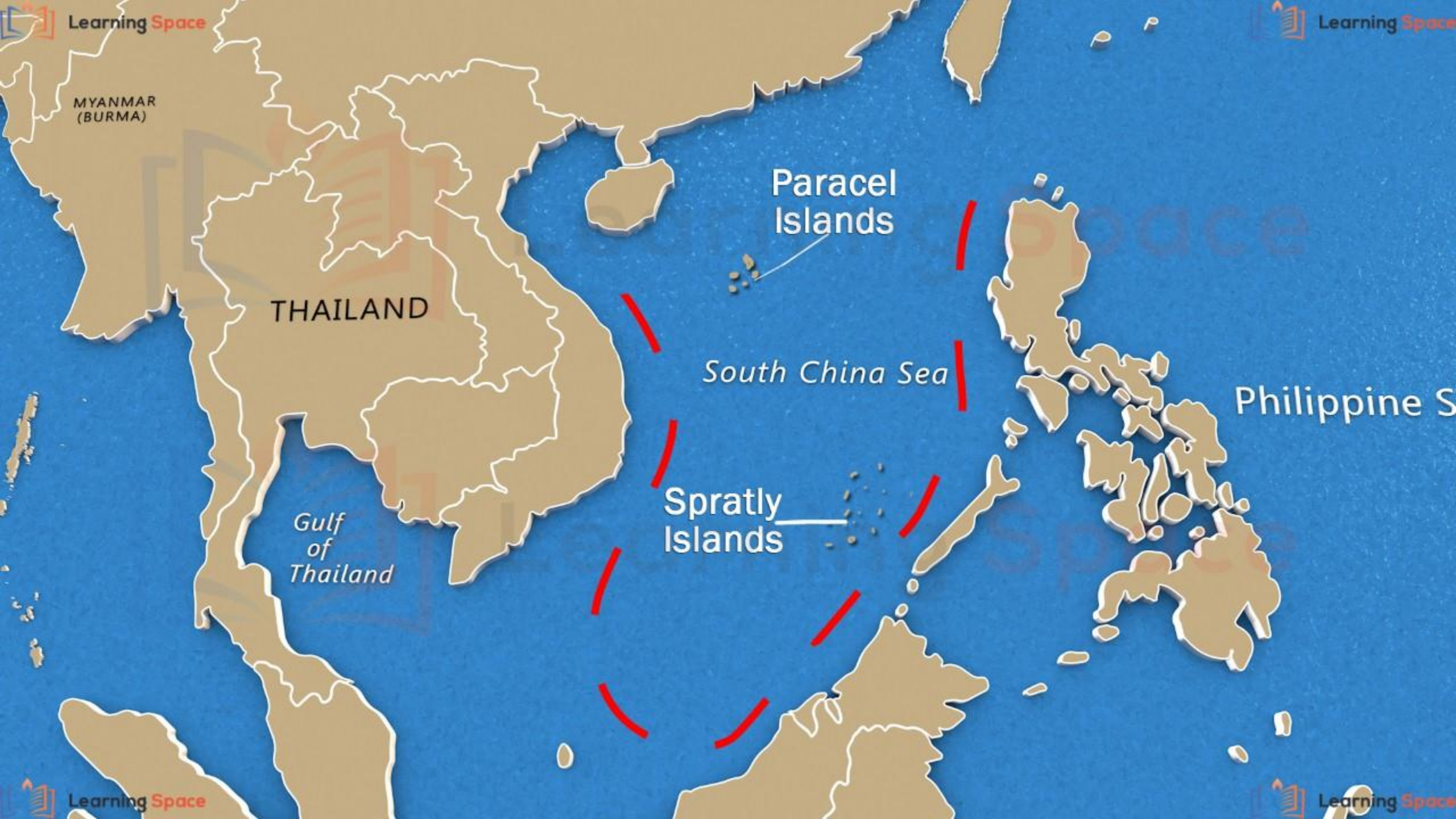
- *Dalai Lama's visit to Tawang.*
- *India's repudiation of BRI.*
- *India's forward leaning posture in South China Sea.*
- *Vietnam's two-year extension of 2006 oil concessions to ONGC Videsh.*



INDIA's POINTS

- *Membership of the NSG.*
- *Issue of Masood Azhar.*
- *Sovereignty issues of CPEC.*
- *Arunachal Pradesh issue*

Learning Space



MYANMAR
(BURMA)

THAILAND

Gulf
of
Thailand

Paracel
Islands

South China Sea

Spratly
Islands

Philippine S



WHAT THE TRI-JUNCTION ISSUE INDICATES?



POINT NO: 1

Unique position of Chumbi valley which is close to the slender Siliguri corridor and a dangerous choke point.





WHAT THE TRI-JUNCTION ISSUE INDICATES?



POINT NO: 2

This is over the interests and rights of the third country, Bhutan and it also indicates wider competition for influence over smaller countries in the region.



WHAT THE TRI-JUNCTION ISSUE INDICATES?

POINT NO: 3

India's trust in Chinese intentions are collapsing steadily.





WHAT THE TRI-JUNCTION ISSUE INDICATES?



POINT NO: 4

Quite often China's actions are irritating India and India feels that several times they are provocative and without any rational basis.



3 Power games at the tri-junction

The current border stand-off suggests India is likely to become bolder in resisting



SHASHANK JOSHI

We should by now be accustomed to Sino-Indian summits occurring with the backdrop of border trouble, and Friday's G20 meeting between a smiling Prime Minister Narendra Modi and a less enthused Chinese President Xi Jinping was no exception. But the Doka La stand-off, at the southern tip of the Chumbi Valley where India, Bhutan, and China meet, is perhaps the most significant of all the border confrontations that have roiled the India-China relationship in recent years. This is not because of its size, dwarfed by the Sumborong Chu crisis of 1986-87, or duration, still only a few days longer than the Daulat Beg Oldi stand-off of 2013. Rather, the importance of the incident is threefold.

What it implies

One factor is the unique position of the Chumbi Valley, which is at once a dangerous conduit into the slender Siliguri Corridor and a dangerous choke point, exposed on both sides, for Chinese forces. A second factor is that this tussle is formally over the interests and rights of a third country, Bhutan, echoing the wider competition for influence in smaller countries – Nepal, Bangladesh, Myanmar, Sri Lanka, the Maldives, and elsewhere – across the Indo-Pacific region. Third, the stand-off comes in a period when it is clear that the wheels are coming off the India-China wagon, with Indian trust in Chinese intentions collapsing



steadily and Beijing taking an ever-more strident tone.

At the military level, India has good reason to prevent Chinese road building near Doka La. Chinese activity has steadily increased in the area beneath Bhutan's claim-line, pushing the area under its de facto control about 5 km southwards, towards a crucial ridge-line. This has a number of implications. It would widen the area of Chinese control in an otherwise very narrow valley, from around 8-9 km (Ditang La to the Amo Chu river) to 12-13 km (Camochen to the river), thereby easing the logistics of moving large numbers of troops. Control of the dominating ridgeline would also give China a strong position, by some accounts even domination, over Indian posts to the west, and Bhutanese ones to the south and east.

India is still well short of matching the impressive infrastructure development in Tibet over the past decade, with two-thirds of sanctioned roads on the Line of Actual Control (LAC) still un-built. But Chinese forces moving through the Chumbi Valley – 90 km from top to bottom – would have long, exposed flanks. India has a formidable set of forces arrayed to the

west, with mountain divisions in Gangtok (17th), Kalimpong (27th), and Binsguri (20th) further to the south, all of which are part of the Siliguri-based 33 Corps. Furthermore, the 59th division of 17 Corps, India's first mountain strike corps, raised for the purpose of offensive operations into Tibet, is headquartered in Panagarh and will reportedly be operational this year. It's worth noting that former National Security Advisor (NSA) Shivshankar Menon has argued, in his 2016 book *Choices*, that Beijing backed down in the 2013 Depsang incident "to a great extent because of India's improved capabilities, which left the Chinese in no doubt that India could embarrass them".

The Bhutan advantage

Another of India's military advantages is its privileged relationship with Bhutan. This allows it to bring to bear large forces from the east. A sizeable Indian Military Training Team (IMTRAT) is permanently based in western Bhutan, while other units regularly cooperate with the Royal Bhutan Army. Bhutan's involvement highlights the way in which Sino-Indian competition is increasingly channelled through third countries, as China relentlessly expands into India's

periphery through summits, trading relations, arms sales. India's intervene forcefully Bhutan-China dispute both of India's interests in the Chumbi its commanding Bhutan, which may have ceded the Dok China in a territorial years ago. The Friendship Treaty, in 2007 to give 'autonomy, still note countries "shall co- with each other on to their national int sense, Bhutan is a step in stepping across a border and defying expectations, India has a degree of confidence more widely." plains the special rhetoric that has seeped out Global Times in rec as lurid promises Sikkim and Bhutan subtler steps such travel advisory for C in India.

There is a reason that this stand-off is weeks, with China road construction troops returning to posts. The risk of pears low. More thickets of border ag malised over the pa 1988, 1993, 1996, 20 serve as an impo whose value is still i ciated.

But the wider co relentlessly harder on both sides. Beiji by the Dalai Lama's in April, India's ag

INDIA & BHUTAN

- 1 India has got privileged relationship with Bhutan.
- 2 A sizeable Indian Military Training Team (IMTRAT) is permanently based in Bhutan.
- 3 India's willingness to intervene in a bilateral Bhutan-China dispute is a reflection both of India's own vital interest in Chumbi valley and of its commanding position in Bhutan.
- 4 India-Bhutan Friendship Treaty, which was revised in 2007 gives Bhutan more autonomy.
- 5 It also says that both the countries shall cooperate closely with each other on issues relating to the national interests.

Hence, Bhutan is a special case.

WE EXPRESS OUR SINCERE THANKS FOR VIEWING THIS VIDEO

Presented by



Learning Space

For Suggestions:

suggestions@learningspace.in

To Contact us:

info@learningspace.in

OUR TEAM

G. V. Rao

D. Sunil Kumar

V. Dayakar James

Y. Sri Poojita

G. Ravi Babu

D. Joji

K. Victor Babu

Visit us at:

www.learningspacedigital.com

0 8 6 6 -2 4 4 4 4 7 2

0 9 8 4 9 9 4 2 2 9 9